

Period pain

The technical term for period pain is dysmenorrhoea. It derives from an ancient Greek expression which literally means 'difficult monthly flow'.

Facts about period pain

Many women experience period pain at some stage in their lifetime. Most women experience some discomfort during menstruation, especially on the first day, but for some the pain is severe enough to disrupt their life. Period pain can be accompanied by premenstrual symptoms such as bloating, tender breasts, swollen stomach, lack of concentration, mood swings, clumsiness and tiredness.

Primary dysmenorrhoea

The pain can be a throbbing or cramping lower abdominal and/or pelvic pain which can start 1 to 3 days before your period, peaking 24 hours after your period starts and subsiding in 2 to 3 days. Some women experience a dull continuous ache or pain which radiates to the lower back and thighs. Some women may also experience nausea, loose bowel movements, headache and dizziness.

The cramping pains are caused by the effect of prostaglandins which are hormone-like substances produced from the womb lining. Prostaglandins cause the womb to contract to shed the lining. There may also be pain caused by the decreased supply of blood to the womb.

For many women, period pain from a normal period cycle can be mild and it does not affect quality of life. However, even though the menstrual cycle is a normal process, it can cause significant discomfort and distress. Effective treatments are available.

Secondary dysmenorrhoea

In some women, painful periods can be caused by a condition such as:

- endometriosis or adenomyosis
- benign growths in the womb – fibroids
- infection – pelvic inflammatory disease

This may not start until your mid-twenties or later. The pain is not restricted to 'time of the month' bleeding and can occur throughout the cycle. Periods may become heavier and more prolonged and intercourse may be painful.

Since secondary dysmenorrhoea can be a sign of other conditions, including pelvic infections, urgent attention may be needed. If you start to experience period pain as an adult you should not hesitate to consult a healthcare professional.

Coping with period pain

There are a number of simple ways to ease the discomfort:

- relax in a hot bath with aromatherapy oils
- cuddle a hot water bottle
- have a back and stomach massage – this is extremely effective for some women
- wear loose fitting clothing in the couple of days prior to and during your period
- do gentle exercise such as yoga – a regular relaxation programme before the period is due and on the first few days can help to relax the muscles and improve blood supply to the pelvic area
- for fast relief, take a painkiller specifically designed for period symptoms

Lifestyle changes

Some women find that period pain symptoms can be eased by lifestyle modifications such as:

- stopping or cutting down smoking – smoking is thought to increase the incidence of period pain by reducing the supply of oxygen to the pelvic area
- reducing alcohol consumption
- eating high fibre foods and plenty of salads and vegetables
- taking daily vitamin E supplements (shown to help some women)
- if eating red meat, ensuring that it is lean, and eating more chicken and fish
- cutting down on sugary foods, chocolate, cakes and biscuits
- reducing the amount of salt in your diet to avoid water retention
- choosing pure fruit juices or mineral water rather than sugary drinks
- taking a supplement containing gamma linolenic acid (GLA) such as evening primrose oil, starflower oil or vitamin B6 to help maintain hormonal balance

If pain persists, visit your healthcare professional for a check-up, and investigations, if needed. Do not put off asking for help if period pain is stopping your daily activities. You might be prescribed:

- non-hormonal drug treatments: tranexamic acid and/or mefenamic acid
- the contraceptive pill: not only will this reduce some of the pain and discomfort but it can make your periods lighter and less painful
- stronger pain killers that you can't buy from a chemist: these should be started as soon as the period starts, don't wait until the pain is at its worst to take them
- an intrauterine device (IUD): this is a very effective method of contraception which may also reduce blood loss and period pain and may be suitable for some women

Useful resources

<https://www.acog.org/Patients/FAQs/Dysmenorrhea-Painful-Periods>

<https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/period-pain/>

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This Women's Health Concern fact sheet provides information and guidance, to be used in consultation with your own healthcare professional. It has been developed by the medical advisory council of the British Menopause Society and it will be updated when guidance changes and/or new data becomes available.

Women's Health Concern is the patient arm of the BMS

We provide independent advice to inform and reassure women about their gynaecological, sexual and post reproductive health.

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